



A Delhi Firm Proves That Open Source Rocks!

Delhi-headquartered Keen and Able Computers has built a business empire on open source technologies. The services-based business model was its route to fast-paced growth.

Everyone 'knew' the world was flat—till Copernicus and Galileo challenged this perception and introduced a new reality. People's initial reaction to the idea of a spherical-shaped Earth was ridicule and hostility. It's a similar situation for companies centred around open source; they constantly battle the common perception that their's is an unviable business model. This exists despite stellar successes like Caldera and Red Hat.

Delhi-headquartered Keen and Able Computers (K&A), a leading Indian open source solutions provider, similarly trumpets the message that you *can* make money in the open source area! Growing at the rate of more than 20 per cent, year-on-year, the group has an annual turnover of over Rs 30 million. A services business model combining training, consulting, customisation and deployment of open source products, along with

support/maintenance, has helped K&A attain this stellar growth and profitability.

"Profitability in the technology business isn't dependent on whether you are in the proprietary or open source domain. There are numerous examples of proprietary software-based companies running into losses. Profitability is dependant on your business model, systems/solutions, ability to plan, execute the plan, and to market yourself. Open source service was the opportunity for us, and we built a strong business model around it," says Varad Gupta, CTO and founder, Keen and Able Computers.

The encounter with open source

In 1996, Gupta and four avid programmers who were determined to write their own software, laid the cornerstone for Keen and Able Computers. However, they soon ran into stormy weather